

L E S S O N 17

The Who, How, and Why of Baptism

6: Baptism

Scripture Focus: *Matthew 28:19-20 · Acts 2:38,41 · Matthew 3:13-17 · Acts 8:36-38*

Who should be baptized? Those who have consciously placed their faith in Christ — “believer's baptism.” How? By immersion, in the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit. Why? Out of obedience to Christ, as a public declaration of faith, and as a testimony of the inward transformation God has already worked in the heart.

BY THE END

You Will...

A	Explain the central discipleship issue in your own words.
B	Connect the main truth to Matthew 28:19-20 and Acts 2:38,41 and Matthew 3:13-17 and Acts 8:36-38.
C	Name one way this truth should shape your thinking, obedience, prayer, or witness.

VOCABULARY

Key Terms

THEME	STUDY NOTE
Baptism	The public sign of identification with Christ and His people, pointing to union with Him in death and resurrection.

THEME	STUDY NOTE
Faith	Trusting God's Word and relying on Christ rather than self, merit, feeling, or religious performance.
Salvation	God's gracious rescue of sinners through the finished work of Christ, received by faith rather than earned by works.
Sin	Any failure to love, trust, worship, and obey God as He deserves; sin separates people from God and requires divine rescue.
Grace	God's unearned favor toward sinners, shown supremely in Christ and active in the believer's growth.

TEACHING NOTES

I. The Main Question

Christian discipleship begins with learning to see The Who, How, and Why of Baptism from Scripture rather than from instinct, habit, or surrounding culture. The goal is not simply to collect religious information, but to have the mind, conscience, and affections trained by God's Word. Who should be baptized? Those who have consciously placed their faith in Christ — “believer's baptism.” How? By immersion, in the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit. Why? Out of obedience to Christ, as a public declaration of faith, and as a testimony of the inward transformation God has already worked in the heart.

A growing Christian asks: what does God require me to believe, reject, receive, or practice? Real maturity includes a clearer love for Christ, a humbler view of self, and a more faithful step of obedience.

II. What Scripture Says

Matthew 28:19-20 and Acts 2:38,41 and Matthew 3:13-17 and Acts 8:36-38 provide the biblical anchor. These passages keep the discussion tied to God's Word and give the learner a stable foundation for reflection. That day of Pentecost that we looked at last time when Peter was preaching and then they accepted the word, received Jesus Christ, it says right away they were baptized and about 3,000 of them were added to the church that day.

Before moving too quickly to application, read the references slowly. Ask what the passage reveals about God, what it says about the human condition, what it commands or promises, and how it points the believer back to Christ. Scripture sets the agenda; Christian reflection follows where God has spoken.

III. The Doctrine Explained

Doctrine matters because discipleship is built on truth. Now, what I want to do is talk about and examine the purpose of baptism in the life of the believer. Doctrine is not a detached category for specialists; it names what every Christian is learning to believe, confess, defend, and practice.

Write the doctrine in your own words. Then ask how it fits into the larger story of Scripture: creation, fall, redemption, and Christian growth. A doctrine has been understood more deeply when it begins to reshape worship, repentance, assurance, humility, courage, and love.

SCRIPTURE SPOTLIGHT

Matthew 28:19-20

Matthew 28:19-20 should be read as more than a proof text. It gives the subject its center of gravity and keeps Christian thinking inside God's revealed Word rather than personal opinion.

Read Matthew 28:19-20 first, then read Acts 2:38,41 and Matthew 3:13-17 and Acts 8:36-38. Notice how the passages work together: one may name the doctrine, another may show its consequence, and another may press the believer toward obedience.

That day of Pentecost that we looked at last time when Peter was preaching and then they accepted the word, received Jesus Christ, it says right away they were baptized and about 3,000 of them were added to the church that day.

Study the passage:

1. What does this passage teach about God, Christ, humanity, sin, grace, or obedience?
2. What word or phrase should control how you understand this truth?
3. How would this passage help a newer believer think more clearly?

FRAMEWORK

Baptism in Proper Order

BIBLICAL ORDER	WHAT TO AVOID
Christ saves by grace through faith.	Treating baptism as the cause of salvation.
Baptism publicly identifies a believer with Christ.	Reducing baptism to a private symbol with no church connection.
Obedience follows faith.	Delaying obedience because every question is not yet answered.

PAUSE & REFLECT

Before moving on, write one sentence answering this: where does The Who, How, and Why of Baptism most need to become clearer or more obedient in your own life?

IV. Common Confusion

Common confusion usually begins when a biblical truth is reduced to a slogan, separated from its context, or filtered through personal experience. Therefore, baptism is not a work that earns salvation, but rather it's an act that reveals what God has already done in my heart. New believers especially need help seeing the difference between a biblical category and a half-true assumption.

When confusion appears, do not answer it only with opinion. Return to the text, define your terms, and make careful distinctions. Stability grows as hard questions are brought patiently under Scripture.

V. Why This Matters for Discipleship

Truth becomes fruitful when it forms the disciple. We talked about why we need to be baptized, the importance of this in our lives, the purpose of it in our Christian walk.

Biblical teaching should train the believer to worship, repent, trust, forgive, serve, pray, resist sin, and speak the gospel with clarity.

Ask where this truth should create maturity. Does it deepen assurance? Correct pride? Encourage obedience? Make Scripture more central? Strengthen witness? The question is not merely whether the content is understood, but what kind of disciple the truth is forming.

VI. How This Changes Daily Life

The Who, How, and Why of Baptism belongs in ordinary Christian life, not merely in a notebook. Now, what I want to do is talk about and examine the purpose of baptism in the life of the believer. Identify one real setting where the truth should matter: a conversation, a temptation, a fear, a decision, a family moment, a church responsibility, or a private habit.

Growing in grace often happens through small, repeated acts of faithfulness. Choose one practice for this week that is concrete enough to obey, simple enough to remember, and biblical enough to strengthen your walk with Christ.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **The Who, How, and Why of Baptism should train the way a believer thinks, worships, and obeys.**
- **Scripture must set the terms before personal experience, church culture, or instinct is allowed to define the issue.**
- **Since baptism is a public confession of personal faith, I've already put my faith in Christ and I'm publicly proclaiming that to the world, baptism then must be preceded by an individual's decision to follow Jesus.**
- **Christian maturity grows as doctrine moves from information into prayer, repentance, assurance, service, witness, and daily faithfulness.**

REFLECTION

Questions for the Lesson

1. *What should become clearer in your thinking about the who, how, and why of baptism?*

2. *Where does this truth correct a common misunderstanding or shallow habit?*

3. *What is one concrete step of obedience, prayer, study, or conversation you should take this week?*

PUT INTO PRACTICE

A Discipleship Conversation

Imagine a newer believer asks you about the who, how, and why of baptism.

They are not asking for a lecture; they need a patient, Scripture-shaped answer that helps them trust Christ and take one faithful next step.

Your Task

1. **Use Matthew 28:19-20 to write a simple, biblical answer in your own words.**

2. **Name one practical step you would encourage this person to take this week.**

3. **Write one prayer request that fits the truth and the situation.**
